

Employers Known for Paying for School

How to use this list: it's a starting map, not gospel. Programs change yearly — before using any number in your Week 4 spreadsheet, **verify it on the company's current careers/benefits page or in a current job posting.** Also: local mid-size manufacturers you found in Week 3 often have tuition benefits that never make lists like this — the only way to find out is to check their careers page or ask in an interview (“does the company offer education assistance?” is a great question that also signals ambition).

Useful background

- The IRS lets employers provide up to **\$5,250/year in tax-free tuition assistance** (IRC Section 127). That's why so many programs land at exactly that number.
- “Tuition reimbursement” (you pay, they pay you back per grade/semester) is different from “tuition paid up front” — up-front programs are much easier when you don't have savings. Note which kind each employer offers.
- Many programs restrict field of study to something job-related — engineering almost always qualifies at these employers, but confirm.
- Ask about **strings**: minimum tenure before eligibility (often 90 days–1 year), GPA requirements, and payback clauses if you quit soon after.

National employers with well-known education programs (verify current details)

Directly in the engineering/industrial world

- **Defense & aerospace:** Boeing, Lockheed Martin, Raytheon (RTX), Northrop Grumman, General Dynamics, BAE Systems — historically strong tuition programs and huge technician workforces. They hire entry-level assemblers and technicians.
- **Industrial/manufacturing:** GE (Aerospace/Vernova), Siemens, Honeywell, Caterpillar, John Deere, 3M, Emerson, Eaton, Schneider Electric.
- **Semiconductors/electronics:** Intel, Micron, Texas Instruments, GlobalFoundries — fabs hire technicians with HS diplomas and are famous for funding associate-degree pipelines with local colleges.
- **Utilities:** almost every regional electric/gas utility has education assistance and technician apprenticeships. Look up *your* utility's careers page.
- **Automotive:** Toyota, Honda, and other manufacturers with US plants; also dealership networks' technician programs.

Not engineering jobs, but famous education benefits (bridge options)

These can fund school while you apply toward technical roles, and some have internal ladders into maintenance/technical work:

- **Amazon (Career Choice)** — funds degrees/certificates including at community colleges; has a maintenance-tech ladder internally
- **UPS (Earn & Learn)** — part-time package handlers get tuition assistance; part-time-friendly for full-time students
- **Home Depot / Lowe's** — tuition programs; store roles also build real product knowledge in electrical/building trades
- **Starbucks, Chipotle, Target, Walmart** — well-known college programs (often through specific partner schools — check whether *your* school qualifies)

A bridge job at one of these is Plan B, not Plan A: Plan A is a technician job that teaches the work *and* helps with school. But a bridge job with a real education benefit still beats a dead-end job with none.

Apprenticeships: the other way employers pay for education

- **IBEW/NECA electrician apprenticeships** — you're paid to work while the program covers your classroom training; journeyman electricians earn a genuinely good living, and the credential is portable everywhere. Find your local at ibew.org.
- **Registered apprenticeships** in machining, industrial maintenance, mechatronics: search apprenticeship.gov by ZIP code.
- Some manufacturers run their own apprentice programs with local community colleges (often called “mechatronics” or “advanced manufacturing” partnerships — ask the community college which local employers sponsor students; the college knows exactly who pays for what).

Verification checklist (per employer, for Week 4)

- ☐ Current benefit found on the company's own site or a ≤6-month-old posting
- ☐ Amount per year, and reimbursement vs. paid-up-front
- ☐ Eligibility wait, hours threshold (full-time only? 20+ hrs?)
- ☐ Field-of-study restrictions
- ☐ Payback clause if you leave
- ☐ Bonus: an employee's firsthand account (Reddit, or your Week 7 interviews) that people actually use it